

3.8 Guidance on Internal Assessment

Introduction

The GCE Sciences share a common approach to centre assessment. This is based on the belief that assessment should encourage practical activity in science, and that practical activity should encompass a broad range of activities. This section must be read in conjunction with information in the Teacher Resource Bank.

Practical and Investigative Skills are assessed in Unit 3 and Unit 6, worth, respectively, 20% of the AS Award (and 10% of the Advanced Level Award) and 10% of the full Advanced Level Award.

There are two routes for the assessment of Practical and Investigative Skills

Either

Route T: Practical Skills Assessment (PSA) + Investigative Skills Assignment (ISA) - Teacher-marked

Or

Route X: Practical Skills Verification (PSV) + Externally Marked Practical Assignment (EMPA) - AQA- marked.

Both routes to assessment are available at AS and A2.

Practical Skills Assessment (PSA)

Candidates are assessed throughout the course on practical skills, using a scale from 0 to 12. The mark submitted for practical skills should be judged by the teacher. Teachers may wish to use this section for formative assessment and should keep an ongoing record of each candidate's performance but the mark submitted should represent the candidate's practical abilities over the whole course.

The nature of the assessment

Since the skills in this section involve implementation, they must be assessed while the candidate is carrying out practical work. Practical activities are not intended to be undertaken as formal tests and supervisors can provide the level of guidance that would normally be given during teaching. In order to provide appropriate opportunities to demonstrate the necessary skills, instructions provided must not be too prescriptive but should allow candidates to make decisions for themselves, particularly concerning the conduct of practical work, their organisation and the manner in which equipment is used.

The tasks

Tasks are provided in the **three areas** of chemistry;